MINORITY PROBLEMS IN COLONIAL BURMA

The economic problems in colonial Burma exacerbated tensions between the indigenous Burman population and the sizeable minority population within the colony. In urban centers such as Rangoon, immigrants arrived from southeastern India and southeastern China. Many immigrants would go back and forth between Burma and their home country. Opportunities in Rangoon led to a large influx of immigrants in the early part of the 20th century. Over 50 percent of Rangoon's population in 1921 was from India. The presence of these groups stirred resentment especially as nationalist fervor was emerging by the 1920s and 1930s. The colonial administrators considered the Burmese unfit to be governed. They were stereotyped as lazy and incompetent. Their educational levels were lowered, leading to a British policy of using the Indians for administrative duties. Furthermore, both the Chinese and Indian populations were heavily involved in commerce and money lending, especially in the urban centers.

THE ECONOMIC SITUATION IN COLONIAL BURMA

Colonialism significantly impacted traditional Burmese economic relationships. The economic situation in precolonial Burma was loosely structured with considerable power situated at the village level. The village head was the point of connection between the peasants and the state. The relationship between the head and peasantry was symbolic. The head provided assistance during times of need or during celebration and ceremonies. The peasant in turn provided needed labor and possibly military assistance.

By the mid-19th century, a large rice-exporting economy was developing in Lower Burma. The growth of the rice export economy (a 600% increase occurred in the late-19th century) led to massive migration from the north. Thousands of northern peasants resettled in the delta from 1870 to 1910.

The political changes connected with colonialism would impact economic and social relations. The village head could no longer be the protector of the peasantry. The agrarian population was much more vulnerable to poor harvests and the overdependence upon a single crop. Furthermore, the colonial administration would not prove to be as flexible